‘brought a sense of belonging to the group’: ‘We believed in it. We grew up from an industry where process and rigour are our way of life. If we did not have it, we could not have risen to the next level or consistently performed’ as required by the Malcolm Baldrige model. It engendered a continuous quest for excellence. ‘This would be the single-most important contribution’ of Ratan’s transformational strategies, he adds.

The TBEM and the BEBP Agreement earned TCS the ‘privilege’ of using the Tata logo and in the process, the company committed itself to adhere to the TCoC and other enhanced standards of operation. ‘Most importantly it [TCS] had also begun its journey in business excellence the Tata way,’ wrote Ramadorai.

After he became the CEO, Ramadorai put in place a ‘cross-functional’ team to implement the core aspects of business envisaged by the TBEM model. The team was tasked to report to him on the progress in improvement, especially on the processes connected with the implementation of the excellence model. This resulted in the adoption of a host of systems to bring about holistic changes in the company, including management systems and the introduction of HR initiatives such as PULSE, to survey employee satisfaction, and SPEED, a performance and personal development programme.

The company was able to ‘put in place a complex and comprehensive system’ to achieve the excellence required. It led to TCS becoming the second company in the group to bag the JRD QV Award in 2004. It was a personal recognition for Ramadorai as well. He had become the CEO of TCS in 1996, just two years after the JRD QV Award was introduced, and had steered the company to a phase of staggering growth, especially between 2000 and 2004, when he was also appointed as its MD.

TCS also benefited from Ratan’s compulsive urge to globalize. Most of the other group companies had first established themselves in the domestic market and then gone global; for TCS, the reverse was true. The enterprise was conceived as a global business as there was virtually no technology budget in India, says N. Chandrasekaran (current group chairman), who had joined TCS as a programme trainee in 1987. The markets for TCS were primarily in the US; there were some in the UK and other advanced nations, but it was all virtually outside India, he adds.

There was a silent push from Ratan to look at foreign operations even before he was in any way associated with TCS. Ramadorai who says that he